Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences Invention
Vol. 4, No. 3, 2022, 51-53
ISSN: 2581-8791

The Ukraine-Russia War and the Indian Response

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Publication Info

Article History:
Received: 07-07-2022
Accepted: 08-08-2022
DOI: 10.35210/jhssi.4.3.3

Keywords:
Invasion, Demilitarization, Denazification, Strategic interests, War crimes, Genocide.

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Abstract

Perhaps no other international incident has become a matter of so much intense political discourse in recent years as the Russian invasion of Ukraine last year and the ongoing conflict between the two countries. This paper examines the genesis and nature of the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and its implications for India and the rest of the world. In response to the conflict India has adopted a stand that is different from other countries of the world keeping in view its own national interest. The paper examines the pros and cons of India's public neutrality stand against Russia and its implications for India with regard to its strategic interests.

INTRODUCTION

Russia's recent invasion of Ukraine and the ongoing conflict between the two countries for almost thirteen months is a matter of grave concern for all the major players of global politics, including India. It has been harshly condemned by most of the countries of the world and the international institutions. But India's reaction to the invasion is different from the rest of the world. Being a democratic country with its declared respect for states' sovereignty and territorial integrity, India was supposed to react harshly against Russia, particularly by the U.S. and Western countries. But India has adopted a neutral stand- neither justifying the invasion nor making any public criticism of Russia, keeping in mind its own national interest in the current international scenario. This paper attempts to examine the genesis and nature of conflict, its implications for India and the pros and cons of distinctive responses of policymakers towards the conflict.

The Genesis and Nature of Conflict

The tension between Russia and Ukraine has a long historical background. Ukraine, a democratic country of 44 million people with over 1000 years of history, happens to be the biggest country in Europe by area after Russia. In 1922, it became one of the original constituent Republics of the 'Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (U.S.S.R.). However, after the fall of the Soviet Union in 1991, it voted for independence from it and since then is being viewed by Russia as an artificial creation carved out from Russia by its enemies as a 'puppet of the West' (Ukraine, 2023).

In 2014, Russia invaded Ukraine and annexed its 'Crimean Peninsula', seizing large part of Eastern Ukraine and fought the army after its Pro-Russian President was deposed. The war has claimed over thousands of lives since then. The tension escalated in 2021 when Ukraine President Zelensky urged U.S. President Joe Biden to let Ukraine join NATO. This has angered Russia because it considers NATO's eastern expansion a threat to its own security. Russian President Putin has constantly demanded guarantee from the West and Ukraine that it will not join NATO. But these countries' refusal provoked Russia, which invaded Ukraine on 24 February 2022 despite the threat of severe sanctions against it by the U.S. and the West. Russian President Vladimir Putin described the invasion as a "special military operation" seeking the "demilitarization" and "denazification" of Ukraine. Challenging Ukraine's "right to statehood," Putin claimed that Ukraine was governed by "neo-Nazis" who persecuted the ethnic Russian minority and justified the invasion, resulting in tens of thousands of deaths on both sides. About 8 million Ukrainians were displaced within their country by June 2022 and more than 8.1 million have fled the country by March 2023 (Russia's invasion, 2023). Russia wants to keep Ukraine under its 'sphere of influence', whereas nearly 80 percent of Ukrainians support independence from Russia. And here lies the crux of the problem.

International Condemnation

The invasion has been widely condemned at the international level. The U.N. General Assembly condemned the invasion by passing Resolution ES-11/1 and demanding a full withdrawal of Russian forces. The International Court of Justice dictated Russia to suspend military operations and the Council of Europe expelled Russia (Bellinger lll, 2022). Many countries imposed sanctions on Russia and it's ally Belarus and provided humanitarian and military aid to Ukraine. Protests occurred around the world; those in Russia were met with mass arrests and increased media censorship. Over 1000 companies left Russia and Belarus in response to the invasion (Allegretti, 2022).

The International Criminal Court opened an investigation into possible crimes in Ukraine since 2013, including possible crimes against humanity, war crimes, abduction of children and genocide during the invasion (International Court, 2022), ultimately issuing an arrest warrant for Putin in March 2023 (International Criminal Court, 2023).

The Indian Response

Indian response to the conflict has been very guarded and distinct from rest of the world, particularly from the U.S. and the West. While India has conveyed its dismay and discomfort over the crisis, it has refrained from publicly condemning Russia as the "perpetrator of the crisis". While expressing its respect for "the sovereignty and territorial integrity of states" and calling for "the immediate cessation of violence and hostilities", it has stressed "dialogue and diplomacy" as the only way to resolve the conflict. However, India has abstained from successive votes in the UN Security Council, General Assembly and Human Rights Council that condemned Russian aggression in Ukraine and thus far has refused to openly call out Russia as the instigator of the crisis. The U.S. and the west are interpreting this Indian response to the conflict as a "Pro-Moscow line" which reflects a sharp divergence of view on a fundamental issue of global order, namely, "the legitimacy of using force to change borders and occupy another nation's territory" with India (Tellis, 2022).

India's Strategic Interests

In fact, a country's foreign policy is primarily determined by its national interest rather than by ideological prescriptions. India has had cordial relations with both Ukraine and Russia; therefore, it deliberately chose not to take sides in the conflict, considering its short-term and long-term strategic interests. One should not forget the fact that Ukraine was recognized by India as a 'sovereign country' in December 1991 after the disintegration of the Soviet Union and established diplomatic relations with it in January 1992. The Indian Embassy in Kyon was opened in May 1992 and Ukraine opened it's Mission in New Delhi in February 1993 (India- Ukraine Relations, 2022). Since then, trade relations and economic co-operation between the two countries has developed on the basis of a long-standing friendship. In March 1992' the treaty of friendship and co-operation was signed between the two providing a major boost to their trade relations. Moreover, Ukraine has been a popular destination for Indian students to study medicine, dentistry and nursing. So, the top priority of our government after the beginning of the conflict was to safely repatriate our students stranded in the war zone. India clearly displayed its dismay and discomfort with the situation. Our External Affairs Minister Subramanyan Jaishankar asserted in Parliament "that the global order is anchored on international law, the UN charter and respect for the territorial integrity and sovereignty of states" and regretted that "the path of diplomacy was given up" (Tellis). In a way India did not like the way Russia invaded Ukraine and expressed it's moral sympathy with Ukraine by offering humanitarian assistance to it.

However, India was cautious enough not to criticize Russia publicly and refrained from identifying it as the perpetrator of the tragedy keeping in view its long-standing and trustworthy friendship with Russia and its security concerns vis-à-vis China and Pakistan.

India perceives both China and Pakistan as "immediate and enduring threats" and believes that "preserving its friendship with Moscow will help to prevent deepening Russian ties with China and to limit Russian temptations to build new strategic ties with Pakistan". Therefore, it has deliberately refrained from openly criticizing Russia with the hope that it would at least minimize Russia's close proximity to both of its rivals i.e. China and Pakistan who undermine India's vital interests.

The Indian policymakers view Russia as a long-standing "dependable partner" right from the days of Soviet premier Nikita Khrushchev who in 1955 publicly declared Moscow's support for India's claims over Jammu and Kashmir. Moreover, Soviet Union has used its veto power in the U.N. Security Council in India's favor on six occasions. During the 1971 India-Pakistan war it supported New Delhi against the U.S. pressure and has never interfered in India's domestic politics, unlike the United States, which has done so on various occasions. Moreover, India's continued dependence on Russia for military equipment restrains it from alienating Russia in any way. Although India has diversified its arm purchases away from Russia during the last two decades, Russia remains a critical and highly desirable source for India because Russian weapons are cheaper than their Western counterparts and are good enough for India's needs. Moreover, Russia has provided India with high-leverage strategic technologies that others are not willing to provide, has pursued the development and co-production of advanced weapons system to include their manufacturing in India, and does not burden India with excessive end-user constraints, thereby making India's defence relationship with Moscow even more valuable (Tellis).

Because of the above-mentioned reasons, our present Central Government led by P.M Narendra Modi still considers Russia a "special and privileged strategic partner" and has focused on revamping cooperation in energy, agriculture and mutual investment thereby further strengthening its special bond with Russia. The two countries have also underscored the importance of continuing close co-operation within the framework of international organizations, including in the context of the Indian Presidency in the G20 and the Shanghai Co-operation Organization. Naturally, therefore, India has shared "fundamental assumptions of Russia's line on the Ukraine direction (TOI, 2022).

It is, however, worthy to note that despite India's special bond with Russia it has not hesitated in expressing its displeasure over Moscow's breach of international norms and has focused on "the humanitarian catastrophe produced by the crisis." If it has avoided the public criticism of Russia so far, it is because of its own strategic compulsions. It has expressed moral sympathy with Ukraine and sought the help of both Ukraine and Russia in repatriating the thousands of Indian students stranded in Ukraine and offered humanitarian assistance to Kyiv. It is, therefore, unfair to blame India for adopting a biased policy towards the conflict. Yet the Policymakers in the U.S. and the West has expressed disappointment over India's stand in the conflict, considering it as a sharp divergence of view "on a fundamental issue of global order, namely, the legitimacy of using force to change borders and occupy another nation's territory through a blatant war of conquest."

Risks Involved in Indian Response

Many political commentators consider India's diplomatic neutrality stand as dangerous and fraught with risks. It is argued that "neutrality positions India as allied to the despotic Russian state personified by Putin rather than to Russia the country." India is also accused of "inconsistency" in its "commitment to protecting the rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific over that in Europe, at a time when it's biggest international partners -economic and strategic- are both united in their determination

to penalize Russia." They find India "in the company of strange bedfellows such as China and Pakistan, which happen to be India's adversaries and have behaved toward India as Russia have toward Ukraine." There is also no surety that India's current stand will actually arrest "the continuing drift toward stronger Sino-Russia ties" (Tellis).

CONCLUSION

Whatever be the consequences of India's "diplomatic neutrality" stand in the ongoing Ukraine-Russia conflict we must understand the fact that our policymakers were confronted with "difficult strategic choices, "and they have chosen the "best of the bad choices" faced by them. Our response to the conflict seems to be fruitful as our country still enjoys the trust of Russia and Ukraine involved in the conflict. Both these countries are now requesting India for mediation to resolve the conflict, which is a victory of India's diplomatic skills. However, it would be premature to conclude that future developments in the context of ongoing conflict will go in India's favor as the dynamics of international politics are very fluctuating.

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